

WHAT IS EQUALITY?

The dream of everyone being equal sounds simple enough. After all, everyone is part of the human race, so we should all be the same. The reality is more complicated. When you start to decide what people should be equal to or whether it is ever fair to be unequal, things get tricky. From the outset, babies are not born equal, as their country of birth, home environment, family, and whether they are born male or female all play a role in how their lives turn out.

IN THE BALANCE

HUMAN RIGHTS

A state of equality is difficult to achieve because everyone has different characteristics and is exposed to different situations. Most philosophers would argue that people should have equal human rights to everyone else. The countries that form the United Nations (UN) have decided that all member nations should be equal and agree on a list of rights and freedoms. These include the rights to life and liberty, freedom of movement, and freedom of thought. There is no universal agreement about human rights, however, and some cultures, religions, and countries have different views on equality.



BROKEN LAWS

There are some situations when it is not possible to treat people equally. One example is criminals who have broken the rules of the country they live in. Extreme lawbreakers, such as murderers, are taken away and put in prison, losing their right to liberty. The way they live is no longer equal to someone who has not broken the law. However, as punishments differ according to the crime, they may also be treated differently to someone who has stolen rather than murdered. A thief may get a shorter prison sentence than a murderer, who might be jailed for life and kept in solitary confinement.

EQUAL RULE

Different countries have different systems of government that decide when people should be treated equally or differently. In democratic countries, the government is voted for by the people that live there. The largest party or group of parties that can work together forms the government. For some nations, the ruler is born into a royal family as the heir to the throne. In a few countries, leaders are decided by a group of individuals selected by the predecessor. This happens in the Vatican, where the pope, who is the head of the Catholic Church, is also the head of state. The governments of countries in the UN are regulated to check that all of the people are treated fairly and get the same health care and education, for example.

